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AFRICA'S NEW TRADITIONAL DANCE

Judith Lynne Hanna¹

African dance is a dramatic microcosm of many of the cultures of which it is a part. Oral history reveals that dance has long been an important medium of African communication. In contrast with modern life in Europe and Anglo-America where behavior is individualistic and segmented (e.g., work from eight to five, dance on Saturday night, worship on Sunday morning), dance in many traditional African societies was communal and almost ubiquitous, a part of significant occasions in an individual's life cycle. These occasions generally fell within the jurisdiction of indigenous religions. There were dances for birth, youth education, adult initiation, worship, work, play, and death. Death assumed the position of causative force because "traditional dance"² was an integral part of indigenous religions characterized by magic and ritual used to communicate with the supernatural and disseminate messages from the gods and spirits.

Today, African traditional dance in most parts of the continent has lost its key position in society. Why has this change occurred? The answer, simply, is that African traditional dance performed religious and socio-economic functions which recent changes in Africa have either caused to disappear or have altered. The imposition of imperial rule, the rise of nationalism, and the post-independence attempts to mobilize the fragile new nation-states are among the forces which have profoundly transformed most traditional societies. In some parts of Africa (a continent diverse in indigenous culture and in the impact of modernity) the changes have been great; in others, they have been slight. However, they have almost everywhere affected the ways of Africans and how these are reflected and translated into dance.

The dances I have observed were manifestations of continuity and change in Africa. This can clearly be seen in the purpose and occasion of traditional dance, as well as in some dance elements. After a review of the forces of change in Africa which have most affected aboriginal dance, I shall report on four aspects of continuity and change: purpose and occasion, costume, accompaniment, and form of movement. Future papers will report on other aspects of change and will analyze in depth the functions and movements of African dance.

Forces of Change

Wherever correctness in style and structure in indigenous dance is part of magico-religious ritual, dance tends to be preserved. Before European contact, changes in such dance generally came from stimuli within the indigenous cultures. In this century, however, indigenous African religions have been buffeted by the forces of change launched by European occupation. These include Christianity, Western education, improved communication and transportation systems, and new urban centers. In many areas Christianity supplanted indigenous religions or caused them to be transformed in accordance with changing needs. (Islamic proselytizing had similar effects in other areas.) Because of the intimate relationship between aboriginal dance and religion, the new religions destroyed the raison d'être of much dance.

The Christian missionaries, with the cooperation of the imperial administrators, probably were most directly responsible for the modification, suppression, or disappearance of traditional dancing. These missionaries, among the first Europeans to come into contact with African societies, recognized that traditional dance was a part of indigenous religion. Even though the dances often had universal themes, and origins comparable to European folk dances, their performance was taken simply as the manifestation of savage heathenism and, therefore, as antagonistic to the "true faith." Most Europeans did not realize what some of them only recently have come to know: many elements of indigenous belief and practice are not necessarily incompatible with Christianity. For example, the retention of old deities while adopting the Christian Deity (often regarded by the African as additional security against the uncertainties of life) may be functionally comparable to the mediation of saints between the individual and the Supreme Being. Traditional dancing on Christian holidays is functionally comparable to some of the European religious celebrations which have their roots in pre-Christian pagan rites.

As well as trying to stamp out aboriginal dance on religious grounds, the Europeans passed secular moral judgments. Within the Victorian frame of morality which existed during the early period of British rule, most African dancing was branded as licentious, bestial display. Few Europeans realized, for example, that dances involving much pelvic movement could, among other things, be a glorification of fertility related to the desire for abundant harvests—a paradigm of life force and an affirmation of life itself. Most Europeans chose to condemn such dances as vulgar sexuality. Furthermore, it was the "white man's burden" to bring his civilization to the black man. This "moral" civilization had no room for the uninhibited and expressive dances of Africa, for they were deemed too obscene, childlike, primitive, noisy, and inferior. African dances were, in other words, threatening to the European superego. This defensive condemnation was passed on to Africans, who were taught—and learned too well—that most things African were inferior to their European counterparts.

Western education, given to Africans to spread the gospel and fill the colonialists' need for administrative and economic manpower, has also affected African traditional dance. When Africans saw that Western education led to material advancement and improved status in society, they began to send their children to missionary and (especially in French-speaking Africa) government schools. Thus many children were removed from their home environments (most African secondary schools are boarding because qualified students are widely dispersed and study facilities are inadequate in the home) at the time when they could learn dances effortlessly, gain skill, and become sufficiently steeped in traditional culture to be an important vehicle for its transmission.

After leaving school, most African youth prefer the excitement and employment opportunities of the town to the quiet and "dirty work" of the village (where, however, they usually plan to retire). Consider, for example, a young Nigerian we met who was the best dancer in his village. He used to spend the evening following his village's weekly market day teaching the children of the village how to do their traditional dances. He and some of his age-mates (all twenty years old) would also perform, for a small fee, on festive occasions as far as ten miles from his home village. Last year, however, he was given an opportunity to drive a taxi in the Nigerian capital, Lagos, over 400 miles away. His departure disrupted, perhaps permanently, the continuity of traditional dancing in his village. Among those who remain in the village, the older illiterate people, although unlikely to forget the traditional dances and not so susceptible to changes as the younger generation, are often too feeble to demonstrate the dynamic young

people's dances; and as the old people die and the few remaining talented, knowledgeable, and interested youths move away, there will be few villagers, if any, to teach traditional dances to the new generations. The sources of accurate knowledge about aboriginal dances will disappear unless the necessary action is taken to preserve or restore traditional culture. (Remedial action now being taken is discussed below.)

With the advent of improved communication and transportation systems and the development of urban centers, many new arenas of interaction, acculturation, and innovation were created. In the urban areas Africans from diverse ethnic groups came to know each other and the European. The ways of the strangers were often emulated; this was especially true of the ways of Europeans who became models for many Africans. Acceptance of new customs was accompanied by the rejection or repression of some traditions and the modification of many others, because these old ways were less prestigious, less useful, or unacceptable to the ruling Europeans.

Villagers are also recipients of this modernity—even those who have had little direct contact with the European. The restless young men from the villages, returning home after working or trading in the towns, import Western culture. Even those villages in which change has been resisted and substantive culture change has been slight have had to modify their practices. For instance, indigenous religious ceremonies and the dances associated with them are now often held on Western or territorial holidays so that the villagers who play vital roles in these ceremonies, some of whom now live and work in towns, can be at home. Within the new arenas of change, traditional dance, where it survives, tends to become modified and to occupy a less ubiquitous and prominent place in the lives of the townsmen and villagers. As in Western societies dance tends toward art, professionalism, and recreation, divorced from everyday life; it also tends to be less collective.

The passing of imperial rule and the irresistible weight of traditional culture have led many African leaders to question ever-increasingly the status which Europeans ascribed to African cultures and to seek anew African cultural values. Amidst the usual uncertainties and anxieties of personal and national identity crises (including the confrontation of such questions as what to retain, reject, accept, modify, and fuse), there has been a legitimation, rejuvenation, and revival of traditional arts. In some areas, the actions necessary for the survival of traditional dance are being taken. However, the new traditional dance is mostly being perpetuated outside its original context. It has changed from primarily a sacred, communal, ritualistic role to more of a profane, theatrical, and recreational role. The imported and mutant religions generally do not find traditional dance useful, although it may even manifest itself in spite of religious doctrines forbidding dancing. We saw an example of this during an Apostolic Church Service held in a small village 20 miles from Ilesha, Nigeria. The physical movements (including the accompanying hand clapping) of the congregation bore strong resemblances to the area's traditional dance movements and gestures. Many other examples of traditional dance being perpetuated outside its original context may be given. War dances asking supernatural guidance and support are, in the new order of religion and administration, less relevant for battle than for building up the society in the modern era. Dancing masqueraders, formerly believed to be supernatural spirits and held in awe or fear, now tend to serve as entertainment. Where traditional dance has been revived, the former purpose has often been modified or forgotten, although there is usually a continuity in movement and generalized meaning. Thus some traditional dance forms and feelings are kept alive.

Purpose and Occasion

The purposes and occasions of contemporary African traditional dances in most of West and East Africa, particularly in the urban areas, have lost some of their original meanings and functions, but along with fusion and substitution, there is continuity. (Observers report similar situations throughout the continent.) Traditional dances continue to be performed on many significant occasions, to be enjoyed as recreation, to be appreciated as cultural heritage, and to be used instrumentally. These dances provide an enhanced feeling of life, for Africans delight in motor expression: everyone—dancers, musicians, and spectators—becomes exhilarated, refreshed, and often catharsized.

Traditional dancing in contemporary Africa, as in the past, takes place on gala occasions such as marriages (perhaps after a Christian church service), installations of chiefs (often warrant chiefs), dedications (frequently a modern school or hospital), celebrations of personal advancement (for example, appointment as judge, election as councillor, graduation from university), welcomes for honored guests, and even Christian holidays. Nevertheless, in many parts of Africa, adult dancing on festive occasions now tends to be less compelling and athletic than in former times because, as discussed earlier, its purpose is no longer so vital, there are fewer able dancers, and the physical strain and sweat involved are often considered uncivilized.

Traditional dancing also remains an important and popular component of leisure life in contemporary Africa. It constitutes an especially important recreational activity for illiterate migrants who organize themselves and regularly dance through urban and suburban areas, usually on weekends and holidays. Traditional dancing gives them a sense of belonging and warmth, and reaffirms their clan or tribal identity in the alien urban environment which is often far from their own homes. Some young people who are fond of dancing form societies for the sole purpose of having traditional dancing. Such groups exist in villages, schools, and various quarters of towns. The more proficient and famous dance societies travel to distant places to perform. Among some ethnic groups (e.g., the Yoruba in Western Nigeria), one also finds women's societies which meet to enjoy traditional dancing. Money is donated at the meetings so that the groups can periodically purchase new cloth for their costumes or contribute to a cause deemed worthy.

Because many Africans have embraced much of Western culture and partially rejected their own, efforts are now being made to resuscitate elements of traditional culture which do not conflict with the programs for modernity. Dance is one such cultural element. Organizations such as Mbari, an African cultural club in Nigeria, foster African arts with numerous concerts and exhibitions. An affiliate of the Congress for Cultural Freedom (an international organization with headquarters in Paris), Mbari has its counterparts elsewhere in Africa.

As part of this cultural renaissance, some African nations already have national dance companies, and more have plans for them in the future. Guinea's Ballet Africain was widely acclaimed for its performances in the United States and Europe. Ethiopia's dance company, the Haile Sellassie I National Folk Music and Dance Ensemble compares favorably with any folk group. Ivory Coast and Senegal also have national dance companies. Last summer, the University of Ibadan, a Nigerian federal institution, sponsored an African dance workshop for highly talented young dancers and musicians; the goal is to form a dance drama company which can perform throughout the world. The Institute of African Studies at the University of Ghana (government supported) has a group of young African dance students. Under Albert Opoku's tutelage, they visit villages and towns

where traditional dancing is taking place in order to participate with the indigenous dancers and learn their movements. The dance students often invite the performers to dance at the university so their movements can be recorded in Lab-notation (a symbolic method of transcribing dance movements) and the accompaniment recorded. Thus some dances are being preserved for posterity. In summer 1963, under the direction of A. A. Nekyon, Minister of Information, Uganda held its first nation-wide traditional dance competition. The best dancers and musicians of each district were selected for training with the hope of having them perform abroad. For the independence celebrations in Kenya, auditions were held in various regions and the country's best traditional dancers were assembled for a spectacular display. Here we saw relatively little Western influence; the members of varied ethnic groups, with pride and dignity, were adorned in their exciting, colorful traditional costumes, performing some of their traditional dances with great skill. Perhaps Kenya will soon have a national dance company.

Each year there are more cultural festivals and conferences. These are on local, regional, national, and sometimes international levels. Generally, dancers and musicians are selected for these events in competitions which induce more people to learn traditional dances and attempt to bring out the best performers. These competitions also introduce many of the performers to the basic rudiments of stagecraft (making entrances, exits, using "stage" space) and tend to encourage perfected dance and enriched choreography. This is particularly true in urban areas which have recreation halls outfitted with Western stage facilities. Because the traditional setting for dance was a village square, compound of a chief or other host, or some sacred area rather than a theater in the Western sense, staging for these events puts new constraints on traditional dance. For instance, it may mean fewer performers than usual, a shorter time period for various movement sequences, the absence of "uncivilized" movements, or different use of directions. By transmitting portions of the cultural festivals, conferences, and competitions, television, a budding communications medium in Africa, is also making its contribution toward stimulating interest in and preserving African traditional dance. Furthermore, television has special programs such as the weekly show of Anyaogu E. Ukonu (producer-director-performer of Eastern Nigeria Television) on which he invites different outstanding traditional dance groups to perform.

For political capital and self-identify, political leaders have begun to take an interest in traditional dance. Political connotations are given to dances and dance-songs, and they are used as propaganda to help spread the images and messages of the political leader and his party. The propaganda can be in the gestures and the costumes. For example, Zikbo, danced by Ubakala clan women (Ibo tribe, Eastern Nigeria), stands for "Zik is the Governor General of Nigeria." The women dance in pairs, facing each other. The "mother" is supposed to be showing her "child" to a friend; they hope that the child will grow up to be like Zik, the leading Nigerian nationalist and now president of the country. It is quite common for dancing groups to outfit themselves in costumes using party colors and symbols, yet dance traditional dances. I saw a poignant illustration of how political emotion has permeated African traditional dancing at a competition of Acholi District, Uganda, to select the best dancers to represent Uganda abroad. In several cases the women from the same village grouped themselves according to political party affiliation and refused to dance together. One women's group, dressed in the colors of the Uganda Peoples Congress, began to sing derogatory things about the Democratic Party while they were dancing. The male musicians accompanying this dancing group, DP supporters, countered by transgressing the

appropriate dance rhythm. Mediators had to be called before the dance could continue. Political overtones were even clearer when the "Katangese Boys," a dance group of men and women from the now reunited Congo (Leopoldville), toured Belgium during the time of the secession of Katanga. In the opening scene of their show, the Katangese appeared united with Belgians under a Katangese flag. Several of the dance-songs were patriotic, in praise of the "country"—Katanga.

Costume

The costumes of traditional African dance generally reflect modernity in contemporary Africa. Before extensive European contact, Africans commonly used dance costume for comfort and aesthetic reasons. Costume often served as an extension of parts of the body to emphasize and inspire movement; as such, it was an important part of dance. Costumes were usually made of materials found in the local area, such as skins, feathers, grasses, dried flowers, and bark. In some areas, and on some occasions, the dancers did not clothe themselves.

Illustratively, consider the dance costumes of the Acholi in Uganda whose costumes are representative of many ethnic groups in Africa. Aboriginally, young Acholi girls merely wore a girdle (a common garment throughout the continent) of approximately twelve fibre threads tied on the right hand side. These girdles were decorated with metal beads and discs hung on the front and back fringes; swinging to and fro in dance, they emphasized the movement of the hips which is predominant in Acholi dance. After puberty, Acholi girls wore two short fibre aprons, one on the front and the other on the back. The older the girls became, the larger and longer were the prescribed aprons and tails. In addition, they wore tail hairs of giraffe or gorgets of coiled brass wire around their necks and coiled wire on their upper arms, wrists, and legs. Flashing in the light of the sun or moon, these burnished ornaments enhanced movement. The boys of Acholi wore a brief rat skin to cover the genitals and the men wore unfitted skins of larger animals around their waists. The male costumes also stressed pelvic action.

Because of the emulation of Europeans, occasional enforcement of European clothing standards, and (to a lesser extent) the relative costs and accessibility of traditional and European materials, few African peoples (including the Acholi) have completely retained the dress used before the coming of the white man. Complete adoption of European dress is more common. Today, men are often found traditional dancing dressed entirely in Western clothes. Even when wearing "traditional" dress, Africans can often be seen with long trousers beneath an animal skin swaying to and fro. In many places a man's jacket, tied around the waist as a substitute for an animal skin, is used to emphasize movement. A man who cannot afford European clothing (new or used) in good condition often settles for the remnants, e.g., a few threads forming a torn network of what was once a shirt.

Nineteenth century Victorian morality, which lingers in contemporary Africa, dictates propriety out of fear of nudity: genitals, torso, and female breasts must be covered. Of course, there has been considerable variation in reaction to this dictate. Many young girls, as well as the more Westernized women, dress in frocks or wrappers and blouses. Most of the other girls (unless still flat-chested) and women usually wear, at the least, wrappers and breast coverings; these latter include the wrapper itself, bandanas, men's signlets, and the type of brassiere Western women wear as an undergarment. The clothing history of Baganda

women is illustrative. Soon after the British arrived in Buganda, the women, who formerly wore bark cloth "strapless" ankle-length dresses, were living and dancing in the *basuti*, a European cloth ankle-length dress which covered the shoulders with high sleeves. The *basuti* is now a "traditional" dress. For the men, the bark cloth toga was exchanged for the *kanzu*, a robe similar to that worn by a Catholic priest, but usually worn under a Western suit coat. The Efiks in Nigeria, too, have adopted as their traditional dress the kind of article they acquired early in their contact with European visiting merchants and missionaries: they wear multi-colored damask skirts with hoops, top hats, and silk handkerchiefs. Costume adornment has also changed throughout Africa. Inexpensive Western costume jewelry may be found in most parts of the continent. Formerly, girl and male dancers in various areas wore leg pellet bells fastened onto pieces of fibers, leaves, cloth, or hide wrapped around the leg. Now army puttees acquired from the African men who served in one of the world wars are often used to protect the legs against the pellet bells and to adorn the legs. There have also been changes in props. The Acholi women, for example, used to carry their lovers' axes in *atoli*, a war dance, or in *apiti*, a dance celebrating the killing of a leopard or glorifying a man's courageous action. Now they carry mirrors or photographs. These new costumes reflect change and the "civilized" status, but they seldom provide the comfort or stimulate and accent traditional movement in the way that the freer and more functional aboriginal costumes did.

Accompaniment

Changes in Africa have also affected the music accompanying dance movement. Many of the traditional dance-accompanying instruments which are difficult to construct or to learn how to play are dying out. The *dingidingi* dance from Acholi District is a clear example. The dance is named after a technically demanding one-string fiddle played with a one-string bow. More often than not, the *dingidingi* dance today is accompanied by an orchestra which does not have a *dingidingi*! There are at least two reasons why such instruments are dying out. First, the would-be apprentices, who in olden times have learned performance and construction techniques by working with skilled elder musicians and instrument makers, are either away at school or in the towns seeking their fortunes. Second, some instruments occupied prominent places in magico-religious ritual dances, and these are less often performed.

What has replaced the traditional instruments? Beer bottles and porcelain pans struck with the hand or a stick take the place of traditional idiophones. Seatless "Western" chairs, empty oil-cans, and two-by-fours have begun to supplant the hollowed-out log as a drum base. Lead dancers use police or army whistles to signal movement pattern changes to their groups. Animal horns and carved flutes are being replaced by Western manufactured instruments. The melody and rhythms of dance accompaniment have also changed. In this respect, phonograph records and radio broadcasts, available in most parts of Africa, have had a profound effect. There are now even a few traditional dance groups accompanied both by drums beating indigenous rhythms and modern guitars playing Western harmonies. The highlife, a westernized traditional dance pattern with steps found in various West African cultures, is absorbing mambo, cha cha cha, and twist themes in its "traditional" drum interludes. And traditional dance-songs are often laced with harmonies learned in Christian mission schools and churches.

Form of Dance

Through the dynamic fusion of the indigenous and the foreign, there is continuity, change, and evolution in the form of new traditional dances. The dingidingi, a dance referred to above, is a young girls' version of nanga, an aboriginal dance in which young married women moved in a circle around the musicians. In the nanga the women would wriggle and execute various other movements as the music inspired them. At any time, a man might rush up to a woman and, through movement, communicate his admiration for her. The nanga was also named after an instrument—a six string zither. To return to the dingidingi, it was first danced shortly after World War II and is a byproduct of African participation in the war: the returned veterans who formed associations needed dancers to perform in order to collect money. Although the movement of dingidingi has much the same style as the aboriginal nanga, its structure has taken on the pattern of Western military formations. While in these orderly formations, the girls, in front of the male musicians, execute a wide range of movements, including a traditionalized (in terms of body movement) twist! The introduction of the twist movement was not difficult: it has in common with the aboriginal style energetic pelvic rotary movements impelled by rapid knee action.

In Ubakala, Eastern Nigeria, a new satiric and mimic dance has evolved which is loosely patterned after European ballroom dancing. To a traditional young girls' "shaking" choral dance, girls in a circle periodically form pairs and shake and caress each other. The name of the dance, Nwagbogho, means "My Girl, Come Waltz With Me." The West African highlife, another example of fusion, combines the structure of Western ballroom dancing with some of the style and generalized meaning of indigenous dance. In many African societies, it was considered highly immoral for a man and woman to dance in public tightly clasped together. Dancing in couples was generally restricted to fertility dances where it was viewed as fulfillment. Today, the imported ballroom dancing position is accepted by most Western educated Africans, and it is commonly used along with indigenous African steps, posture, gesture, manipulation of hips and buttocks, earthy quality, meaning (an affirmation of life), and function (e.g., emotional release, exhibition of skill, and display of sexual attractiveness).

The swift, sometimes disruptive, changes caused by Western intrusion have created neuroses and psychoses in some Africans. One of the results of this development has been a new and unusual dance form. Perhaps it should be called the "dance of deviance." I have seen the almost identical dance in Ghana, Nigeria, Kenya, and Uganda. It is a solo performed on occasions for traditional dancing. The costume is rags, pieces of skin, feathers, or combinations of these. The movements and self-accompanying instruments seem only to be distantly related to those of the performing groups; perhaps the behavior of the deviants is the expression of some deep internal drama using the language of dance. Usually, these deviants, recognized by the indigenous people as "crazy," are tolerated. However, they are not incorporated into the performing groups and when the occasions for traditional dancing are over, they leave quietly and alone.

The new forms of dance which are entering traditional repertoires sometimes enrich aesthetically; sometimes they adulterate. As a result of the forces of change, local cultures tend to be submerged within the world culture. It will be unfortunate for the world of dance if African dances lose their uniqueness and become homogenized in the Western mold. Historically, the tragedy is that art is one of Africa's great contributions to the world. The instructionalization of traditional dances in the newly independent states of Africa provides one buffer to

homogenization. Several efforts in this direction have been discussed. Another buffer is dance research. Large areas of ignorance exist in dance history, and especially in knowledge about African dance. Much extensive work should be done to record and analyze the aboriginal and new traditional dances of Africa. The rapidity of change in Africa makes such research a matter of urgency.

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FOOTNOTES

1. This paper is a first report on my 1963 dance research in East and West English-speaking Africa. One of my projects was to observe traditional African dances, record some examples of them (using a 16mm Bell and Howell camera, a Robot 35mm rapid sequence camera, and a Stencil Hoffman 7 1/2 ips double-track tape recorder), explore the social framework of these dances, and then analyze their style and structure.

During my year in Africa, I was a research associate with Dr. William John Hanna of the African Studies Center, Michigan State University, and a Visiting Associate of the Institute of African Studies, University of Ibadan. I wish to acknowledge the Center's support for the research upon which this article is based and the Institute's help during the Nigerian phase of the research. In addition, I would like to thank Dr. Hanna, Mrs. Gertrude P. Kurath, and Mr. Benjamin Dennis for their critical reading of this article; the Hon. A. A. Nekyon (Minister of Information, Broadcasting and Tourism, Uganda), Chief J. O. Ebere and the Ubakala Clan (Eastern Nigeria), Mr. Alan Chatterton (Senior Press Officer, Ministry of Information, Broadcasting and Tourism, Kenya), and Mr. Sol Olek of Acholi District (Uganda) for assisting in the collection of data; and Mr. Adhemar Byl, a spectator at the "Katangese Boys" performance in Bruges, for reporting the incident to me.

2. The term "traditional dance" is herein defined as dance in an ethnic group which is considered by most members of the group to be their cultural heritage and which has not been created or introduced by most of the current participants.

